able to a CM even after ceasing to be an MLA, using that period to approach the courts against a disqualification. "In case this becomes untenable, he can pick a member of his family as a stopgap successor, such as father Shibu Soren, mother Rupi Soren or wife Kalpana," says a close aide of the chief minister.

Ever since it was carved out of Bihar in November 2000, Jharkhand has seen frequent changes in government, with MLAs switching sides. The state has so far had 11 governments and three stints of President's rule—the last ending in 2014. The BJP has led five of these governments, and had once backed Shibu Soren's JMM regime before pulling the plug on him in May 2010. The JMM has also led the government five times, besides backing the Madhu Koda-led UPA government in 2006-08. The BJP's Raghubar Das, who took over in December 2014, has been the only chief minister to complete a full term. Hemant stormed to power in December 2019, ousting the Raghubar Das-led government. Though he leads a coalition with a comfortable majority, the situation in the assembly may change to his disadvantage if a handful of the MLAs quit or switch sides.

As things stand, the JMM and the BJP are the two political pivots in Jharkhand. With their respective dominance unmistakably clear, it seems one of the two parties needs to cut short the other in order to gain the electoral upper hand. Now, while the lawmakers are expected to have a good time at a Chhattisgarh resort, all eyes are on Bais to pronounce what the EC has recommended and set off the next act in Jharkhand's political circus. Keep an eye out for the circus horse tricks. ■

TELANGANA

# A COMMOTION MADE OF CLAY

By Amarnath K. Menon

GETTY IMAGES



**GREEN GANESHAS** An artisan makes clay Ganeshas near Hyderabad

In an ironic quirk of politics, Telangana is seeing heightened emotions over both the idols of a deity and an aniconic faith. On the one hand, the T. Raja Singh affair kept the atmosphere tense into the second week. The controversial video put out by the BJP's suspended Goshamahal MLA, with offensive references to Prophet Mohammed, brought into play all the usual plot elements: arrest, bail, protests, calls for decapitation in public and on social media that led to more cases and an appeal for security cover even from Singh's lawyer, and a legal drama that has reached the Supreme Court. On the other, the BJP turned the quest to have an eco-friendly Ganesh Chaturthi on August 31 into another occasion for confrontation with the ruling Telangana Rashtra Samiti.

The green Ganesh Chaturthi is built around two aspects. One, clay replaced plaster of Paris (PoP) and synthetic colours in at least half of the 100,000-odd big Ganesha idols—those over five feet tall. The tallest idol, a 50-feet Ganesha costing over Rs 1 crore that has come up at Khairatabad, is made of clay. The Telangana government has also spent over Rs 1.5 crore to prepare and distribute 600,000 smaller clay idols for free in pursuit of the eco-friendly ideal. The festivities are to culminate with immersions on September 9, which is where part two of the plan comes in. In accordance with a 2021 Supreme Court order, immersion of PoP idols in Hussain Sagar, the historic 5.7 sq. km lake in the heart of the city, stands banned from this year.

This is what the political dispute centres around too. There is no ban per se, as yet, on the use of PoP and synthetic materials in the making of the idols. But what's unsettling the TRS government is the fact that the Bhagyanagar Ganesh Utsav Samithi (BGUS), a BJP-dominated umbrella organisation that oversees the pandals, is insisting on the immersion of PoP idols in Hussain Sagar—as has been happening for the past 43 years since 1,500 idols were

**THE POLITICAL WATERS WERE TROUBLED TO BEGIN WITH. THE IDOL IMMERSION DISPUTE ONLY ROILS IT FURTHER**